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Special session in California to protect against Trump

December 3, 2024 | Seattle Times, The (WA)
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Page: hAh15
OpenURL Link

SACRAMENTO, Calif. — California Gov. Gavin Newsom and state lawmakers returned to the state Capitol on Monday to begin a special session to protect the state's progressive policies before another Trump presidency.

The Democratic governor, a fierce critic of President-elect Donald Trump, is positioning California to once again be the center of a resistance effort against the conservative agenda. He is asking his Democratic allies in the Legislature, who hold supermajorities in both chambers, to approve additional funding to the attorney general's office to prepare for a robust legal fight against anticipated federal challenges.

Democratic Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel on Monday introduced legislation to set aside $25 million for legal fees to respond to potential attacks by the Trump administration on state policies regarding civil rights, climate change, immigration and abortion access.

"While we always hope to collaborate with our federal partners, California will be ready to vigorously defend our interests and values from any unlawful action by the incoming Trump Administration," Gabriel said in a statement.

California sued the first Trump administration more than 120 times to various levels of success.

"We're not going to be caught flat-footed," Newsom said at a recent news conference.

Trump often depicts California as representing all he sees wrong in America. Democrats, who hold every statewide office in California and have commanding margins in the Legislature and congressional delegation, outnumber registered Republicans by nearly 2-to-1 statewide.

Trump called the Democratic governor "Newscum" during a campaign stop in Southern California and has relentlessly lambasted the Democratic stronghold over its large number of immigrants in the U.S. illegally, homeless population and thicket of regulations.

Trump also waded into a water rights battle over the endangered delta smelt, a tiny fish that has pitted environmentalists against farmers and threatened to withhold federal aid to a state increasingly under threat from wildfires. He also vowed to follow through with his campaign promise of carrying out the mass deportation of immigrants without legal status and prosecuting his political enemies.

Before the special session began, state lawmakers swore in more than two dozen new members and elect leaders for the 2025 legislative session. Lawmakers voted to convene the special session largely along party lines.

Hundreds of people also demonstrated around the Capitol on Monday to urge the Legislature to try to stop Trump's mass deportation plans.

They carried banners that said "Not one cent for mass deportation" and "MAGA out of California."

"With the results of the presidential election, we need our state elected officials to use every tool and every resource they have available to them to protect our immigrant Californians," protester Deborah Lee said.

Republican lawmakers blasted Newsom and his Democratic allies over the special session. State Sen. Kelly Seyarto, a Republican representing Murrieta in Southern California, said the special session proposal would make California

have a more adversarial relationship with the federal government.

“What we’re doing today is sending that exact message — that we are going to fight tooth and nail for everything. And you know what? That means they’re going to fight us tooth and nail for everything,” Seyarto said of the incoming Trump administration if the legislation gets approved.

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  NGUYEN, T. (2024, December 3). Special session in California to protect against Trump.*Seattle Times, The (WA),* p. hAh15. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/19D3EC9351C9DD10.